

THE DECISION TO FIGHT

TEXT: Judges 6:1-12 NKJV *“Then the children of Israel did evil in the sight of the LORD. So the LORD delivered them into the hand of Midian for seven years, 2 and the hand of Midian prevailed against Israel. Because of the Midianites, the children of Israel made for themselves the dens, the caves, and the strongholds which are in the mountains. 3 So it was, whenever Israel had sown, Midianites would come up; also Amalekites and the people of the East would come up against them.4 Then they would encamp against them and destroy the produce of the earth as far as Gaza, and leave no sustenance for Israel, neither sheep nor ox nor donkey.5 For they would come up with their livestock and their tents, coming in as numerous as locusts; both they and their camels were without number; and they would enter the land to destroy it.6 So Israel was greatly impoverished because of the*

Midianites, and the children of Israel cried out to the LORD. 7 And it came to pass, when the children of Israel cried out to the LORD because of the Midianites,8 that the LORD sent a prophet to the children of Israel, who said to them, ‘Thus says the LORD God of Israel: I brought you up from Egypt and brought you out of the house of bondage;9 and I delivered you out of the hand of the Egyptians and out of the hand of all who oppressed you, and drove them out before you and gave you their land.10 Also I said to you, I am the LORD your God; do not fear the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you dwell. But you have not obeyed My voice’. 11 Now the Angel of the LORD came and sat under the terebinth tree which was in Ophrah, which belonged to Joash the Abiezrite, while his son Gideon threshed wheat in the winepress, in order to hide it from the Midianites.12 And the Angel of the Lord LORD appeared to him, and said to him, ‘The LORD is with you, you mighty man of valor’!”

INTRO: I have come here to start a fight! My purpose today will be to walk you through a process that will help you to decide whether or not you should start a fight with the devil. The two responses most of us have with regard to hardship, danger and controversy is...

- Flight... *“Run if you want to, run if you will, but I came here to stay – It’s a battlefield brother, not a recreation room, it’s a fight and not a game – Run if you want to, run if you will, but I came here to stay.”*
- Fight... This could very well be the moment that everything in your life turns on a dime and you make the decision to no longer roll over and play dead for the enemy.

So, how do I know when to flee and when to fight? I want us to look at three determining factors that assist us in making a good decision about whether or not to fight.

I. PURPOSE

In the text that I read to you, we are introduced to a farmer named Joash and his son Gideon. The story of Gideon is a very familiar story but the background of the story is somewhat forgotten.

It seems the Midianites and Amalekites have been oppressing Israel for several years. The Israelites would plant, tend, irrigate, and do all the things for bringing a crop to maturity. When it came harvest time the Midianites and Amalekites would come upon them and take the harvest for themselves. The Bible says “***They encamped against Israel.***” They had become so comfortable with harvesting the crops that they did not sow or work, that they fully expected to come into the harvest without resistance. (They brought their motor-coaches, RV’s, travel trailers and tents)

They didn’t come with tanks and weapons, they came with equipment for hauling off the

harvest. And, the Israelites just stood idly by and let it happen! (Sound familiar?)

Gideon had watched this scene being repeated year after year. This activity had no doubt become a source of irritation for him. Verse eleven says ***“Gideon threshed wheat in the winepress, in order to hide it from the Midianites.”*** Gideon and his family were so intimidated by the enemy they had to hide out just to thresh enough wheat to keep starvation from becoming a reality.

The very attitude with which the Midianites and Amalekites eventually irritated Gideon to the point of considering putting up a fight. Being irritated to action is the stuff that miracles and deliverance are made of! (Sheer adrenaline can do amazing things)

What kinds of things has the enemy been doing repeatedly in your life that has you irritated

enough that maybe you can see the purpose for a fight?

While farming is a noble profession, it is not the place that you would normally look for a new hero in a time of national crisis. (You would normally look in the White House, through the halls of Congress, the universities and best think tanks; wouldn't you?)

When the purpose is important enough, the fight for a turnaround can begin in very ordinary circumstances and surroundings.

In the winepress Gideon discovered his purpose, and that purpose would lead him down a very precarious path of danger and victory. By the way, you will probably never have victory without picking a fight that will be dangerous but nonetheless victorious.

The second factor that will determine whether you should take flight, or stand and fight, is...

II. COURAGE

Gideon knew the task would not be easy. The things we will be called upon to do in the middle of a fight, are never simple:

- The Three Hebrew Children...
- Daniel in the lion's den...
- David killing Goliath...

Gideon was not sure the task was even do-able! This is what faith looks like... *“God can do anything, I believe (Hope) He will do this!”*

None of the heroes of the faith had any way of knowing the final outcome of their mission beforehand, they only knew the purpose demanded courage!

There is a song by Bethel Music that talks about:

- The greatness of His renown...
- The waves of Heaven crash over us...
- The greatness of the God of Heaven...

- The Lord drawing us out beyond the shore...
- The Lord is for us and not against us...
- The Lord making us brave...

Up until this point Gideon was a chicken! He was a coward, along with his father, his family, and everyone else in Israel! He was ***“Hiding in the winepress while threshing wheat.”***

While considering whether to flee or fight, our purpose makes us brave enough to spring into action...

III. ACTION

Judges 6:11-12 NKJV ***“Now the Angel of the LORD came and sat under the terebinth tree which was in Ophrah, which belonged to Joash the Abiezrite, while his son Gideon threshed wheat in the winepress, in order to hide it from the Midianites.12 And the Angel of the LORD appeared to him, and said to him, The LORD is with you, you mighty man of***

valor!” The word “**valor**” as it is used here means:

- Strong...
- Mighty...
- Forceful...
- Efficient...

I want us to get a good visual here: Gideon was hiding out, because he was afraid of the Midianites and the Amalekites. He was threshing wheat, and the Angel say’s “***The Lord is with you, you mighty man of valor***”!

I believe while Gideon was threshing wheat he was trying to decide whether to keep hiding or to take action and fight!

During WWII England was being attacked by Germany. With London being bombed around the clock the British people began to lose heart, then one man, Sir Winston Churchill stepped to a microphone and uttered these heartening

words: ***“We shall fight on the seas and the oceans, we shall defend our Islands, we shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight on the hills; but we shall never surrender.”*** This must be how Gideon felt that day! Gideon knew it was time for someone to step up to the plate of action, and he may not have even known that someone would be him!

Naivety is the one quality that allows for greatness without supporting superficial arrogance.

Here is what I think happened in Judges Chapter six: As a young boy Gideon had played Israelites and Midianites with his brothers, cousins, and friends. This was done in the same way we Texans would play cowboys and Indians. The cowboys and Israelites always win, not without a battle, but they always win.

In his own imaginary world Gideon had fought the Midianites and Amalekites a hundred times or more, and had never lost one battle! He imagined coming home to a hero's welcome, being the grand Marshall of the parade, etc...

When Gideon became a young man, he quit playing Israelites and Midianites, but in his mind he continued to fight that battle and win that war! In his mind he kept coming home to a hero's welcome!

On this day, while Gideon was hiding out, threshing wheat for his father; in his subconscious he had just returned from destroying the Midianites and Amalekites, and was being carried through the streets of the capital city; unbeknown to Gideon the Angel of the Lord was sitting close enough to read his thoughts; and the angel of the Lord said “***The Lord is with you, you mighty man of valor***”! In other words: “***stir yourself; do what is in your***

heart and God will be with you and will prosper your way". (Talk about angels here – We command angels – They are awaiting our instructions – Randy Lowe – Mr. Stanton)

Gideon knew, and you know, winning the war would not be as easy as all that; but it never is, is it? Look at what Gideon had to overcome to make the dream a reality, and become Israel's hero:

- He single-handedly destroyed Baal worship... (Throwing down the altars and cutting down the groves)
- He outlasted threats on his life... (After coming back from the war, Sir Winston Churchill was confronted by an irate lady who said, ***"If I were your wife I would put poison in my tea"***. Churchill calmly replied ***"Madam if you were my wife I would put poison in my own tea"***).
- He overcame the loss of 22,000 professional quitters...

- He patiently endured the loss of 9,700 short-sighted soldiers...
- He courageously confronted an innumerable host of Midianites and Amalekites with a pitcher, a lantern, and a shout of praise to God...

The decision was finally made that day to fight and the victory was won! Gideon went from being a ranch hand to judging the people of Israel. God anointed an unlikely person who decided to get in the fight, and he made God's FAITH HALL OF FAME in Hebrews 11.

CONCLUSION:

Who knows how many of God's un-developed and under-developed heroes are in this place today? Only time and opportunity will tell the final story! Don't allow the hero that is within you to go unrevealed because you;

- Failed to see the purpose...
- Lacked the courage...

- Failed to take action...